

**Unit 1, Option A,
Topic A3: The
Angevin Empire,
1154-1216**

The focus of this option topic is on the reigns of the first three Plantagenet kings, Henry II and his two sons. Whilst the phrase 'Angevin Empire' is used in the title, this is recognised as being the invention of later historians and having no contemporary usage. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the specification bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the specification bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four bullet points of this topic offer a framework for understanding the themes of royal power and control and challenge to that power and control. Bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, the importance of England as a source of revenue for their struggles in France runs through all bullet points and the relationship of Church and state is theme linking bullet points 2 and 4.

The first bullet point relates to the creation of the impressive power block under the personal control of the son of Matilda and Geoffrey of Anjou. Students should understand the geographical extent of Henry's lands, encompassing the kingdom of England, the lordship of Ireland, the duchies of Normandy and Aquitaine, and the counties of Maine and Anjou, to which he added Brittany on his brother's death in 1158. Students should understand the disparate nature of this block and the personal link that Henry provided, exercising differing degrees of effective control according to his relationships with his subordinate barons.

The second bullet point relates to the important developments in Henry's governance of his English kingdom and his revival of his grandfather's extensive royal powers. Students should understand the ways in which developments in legal procedures increased the strength of the king as liege lord and that the Exchequer was reactivated. They should understand why there was tension between Church and state and the ways in which Becket enhanced this tension after 1162, culminating in his murder in December 1170.